

Herbert Marcuse and “False Needs”

Abstract: Herbert Marcuse’s claim that people may have superimposed “false needs” (vs. authentic “true needs”) has been criticized by a number of commentators. These critics argue that if all human needs are sociohistorically conditioned, as Marcuse believes, that effectively means that all needs are superimposed on us, and are thus, “false.” I defend Marcuse’s distinction by drawing attention to his expressed definition of false needs as those which perpetuate harm upon satisfaction. Marcuse’s distinction between true and false needs is not a reiteration of the distinction between needs and wants, as his critics claim, but is rather a recognition that in our society, we are forced to need things that ultimately do not lead to our individual (or collective) benefit.

In *One-Dimensional Man*, Herbert Marcuse claims that advanced industrial society maintains its dominance through the production of “false needs.”¹ According to Marcuse, these false needs are “superimposed upon the individual by particular social interests in his repression,” and serve to “perpetuate toil, aggressiveness, misery, and injustice.”² Marcuse’s motivations in *One-Dimensional Man* are clear: he wants to see materially affluent societies reorganize themselves in ways that will free individuals from alienation. But Marcuse believes that too many people are prevented from desiring such reorganization in the first place because of the material affluence that advanced industrial society promises. In his view, most people in this society are so concerned with false needs that they fail to recognize ways in which society fails to minister to their *true* needs. This resulting mass ignorance of our society’s shortcomings prevents the birth of the kind of “radical subjectivity” that sociopolitical revolution requires.

¹ Herbert Marcuse, *One-Dimensional Man: Studies in the Ideology of Advanced Industrial Society* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1964), 4-5.

² Marcuse, *ODM*, 5.

A number of commentators have dismissed Marcuse's distinction between true and false needs with two main objections.³ Those who voice the first objection claim that Marcuse's declaration that our non-vital needs are socially-constructed suggests that *all* of our needs are superimposed. If all of our needs are "manufactured," it becomes more difficult for us to determine which needs are true and which are false. Those who raise the second objection argue that Marcuse's need theory promotes elitism with its implication that many people ultimately do not know what is in their best interests. Those who are deceived by false needs are apparently in need of an enlightened vanguard to tell them what their true needs are.

Herein, I address the first of these two objections.⁴ I am primarily concerned with the internal coherence of Marcuse's conception of false needs, and thus will defend his ideas in this arena against the critique offered by his pupil, William Leiss. In my view, everything hinges on a proper understanding of Marcuse's definition of false needs: false needs are not wants masquerading as needs, but rather, they are *actual* needs that produce *harmful* side-effects upon their satisfaction. The problem is not that individuals make poor choices as much as it is that our society is designed to make even our good choices result in continued domination and misery.

³ Marcuse's thesis of false needs is explicitly rejected in a number of texts. See Christian Bay, "Human Needs and Political Education," In *Human Needs and Politics*, ed. By Ross Fitzgerald (New York: Pergamon Press, 1977): 1-25; Hans Magnus Enzensberger, *The Consciousness Industry: On Literature, Politics, and the Media* (New York: Seabury Press, 1974); Antony G. N. Flew, "Wants or Needs, Choices or Commands," In *Human Needs and Politics*, ed. By Ross Fitzgerald (New York: Pergamon Press, 1977): 213-228; William Leiss, *The Limits to Satisfaction: An Essay on the Problem of Needs and Commodities* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1976); William Leiss, "Needs, Exchanges, and the Fetishism of Objects," *Canadian Journal of Political and Social Theory* 2.3 (Fall 1978): 27-48; Kai Nielsen, "True Needs, Rationality and Emancipation," In *Human Needs and Politics*, ed. By Ross Fitzgerald (New York: Pergamon Press, 1977): 142-156; Ross Fitzgerald, "Abraham Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs – An Exposition and Evaluation," In *Human Needs and Politics*, ed. By Ross Fitzgerald (New York: Pergamon Press, 1977): 36-51.

⁴ In the present project I am concerned with the "internal" workings of Marcuse's false needs, as opposed to its further implications. I do think, however, that the charges of elitism in Marcuse's work are overstated. For more on this topic, see Ross Fitzgerald, "Human Needs and Politics: The Ideas of Christian Bay and Herbert Marcuse," *Political Psychology* 6.1 (1985): 87-108; and Flew, "Wants or Needs, Choices or Commands," 213-228.

This paradoxical phenomenon of fulfilled needs that lead to harm stands as evidence supporting Marcuse's claim that advanced industrial society is "irrational as a whole."⁵

Terminological Background⁶

The distinction between needs and wants is one of the more notorious topics within need theory, and it deserves mention here. Commentators who distinguish needs from wants today usually do so by relating the pair to the dichotomy of objectivity and subjectivity: wants are characterized as subjective in nature, while needs are said to be objective.⁷ For instance, Alison Assiter and Jeff Noonan define "needs" as "universal human life-necessities," which are defined in turn as those things which cause objective harm to any human being deprived of them.⁸ "Objective harm," then, is defined by John McMurtry as "reductions in fundamental organic capabilities," such as "sentience, movement and thought at levels sufficient for leading a healthy,

⁵ Marcuse, *ODM*, xli.

⁶ Marcuse's need theory suffers from a general failure to clearly define relevant terms in satisfying ways; thus, we will begin our discussion by clarifying a few of these important terms.

⁷ The alleged objectivity of needs is a matter of debate in the relevant literature. A number of commentators express concern about the normative implications of designating particular things as needs, especially since some social scientists expressed hope that needs might bridge the chasm between "what is," and "what ought to be." When I say that human beings have a need for X, I imply that human beings ought to have X. This subjective investment raises red flags for those who seek truly objective, empirical descriptions of needs. For more discussion of this subject matter, see Ross Fitzgerald, "The Ambiguity and Rhetoric of Need," In *Human Needs and Politics*, ed. by Ross Fitzgerald (New York: Pergamon Press, 1977), 195-212.

⁸ Alison Assiter and Jeff Noonan, "Human Needs: A Realist Perspective," *Journal of Critical Realism* 6.2 (2007): 176: "By 'universal life necessity' we mean that when any human being, wherever situated, whatever gender or ethnicity might also define them, and whatever particular conception of the good they hold, is deprived of the objects that satisfy these needs, they will suffer comparable forms of objective harm."

Another definition along these lines is found in M. Brewster Smith, "Metapsychology, Politics, and Human Needs," In *Human Needs and Politics*, ed. Ross Fitzgerald (New York: Pergamon Press, 1977), 127-128: "If we try to keep the word 'need' close to its everyday meanings, we use it to refer to *requirements* of the person as a biological and human system – for substances or relationships or states of affairs in the absence of which the person fails to develop or to function normally and may even falter or die."

self-determined, individually meaningful and socially valuable life.”⁹ Though this emphasis on objective harm as the consequence of unmet needs is intended to distinguish needs from wants, the distinction breaks down when McMurtry includes the bit about *individually* meaningful life: at times, human beings may have an objective need for the satisfaction of their subjective wants.

William Leiss also critiques simple distinctions between needs and wants along these lines when he points out that those who promote such a contrast usually overemphasize the quantitative dimension of needs while they underemphasize their qualitative dimension.¹⁰ In Leiss’s view, problems arise when we talk about needs as abstract minimum standards of living. According to Leiss:

All the most interesting and important issues arise when we study how the objective necessities of human existence are filtered through the symbolic processes of culture and of individual perceptions. In short, all the most important issues arise just in that nebulous zone where the so-called objective and subjective dimensions meet. It is trivial to calculate the need for food in terms of minimum nutritional requirements, for example. The real issues are: What kinds of foods? In what forms? With what *qualities*? And how does the perceived need for certain kinds of foods stand in relation to other perceived needs? If we attempt to answer these questions, the distinction between needs as objective requirements and wants as subjective states of feeling breaks down.¹¹

Leiss makes some important observations here, particularly in his observation that discussions of needs and wants often frame needs as if they only pertain to bare survival, or mere existence.¹² A clean distinction between needs and wants breaks down when we talk about them at the level of individual flourishing, as opposed to bare survival or mere existence. Human

⁹ John McMurtry, *Unequal Freedoms* (Toronto: Garamond, 1998), 164.

¹⁰ Quantitative need satisfaction concerns “how much” of some resource x one’s needs for satisfaction. Qualitative need satisfaction concerns the “quality” required for some resource x to satisfy one’s needs. See William Leiss, *The Limits to Satisfaction: An Essay on the Problem of Needs and Commodities* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1976), 61-63.

¹¹ Leiss, *Limits to Satisfaction*, 62.

¹² By “bare survival, or mere existence,” I mean something like the lowest-possible-quality state of being alive; a state of being “technically” alive in a biological sense, without meaning, purpose, fulfillment, experience, consciousness, growth, hope, satisfaction, happiness, etc. This is opposed to *living*, a state of being in which one experiences such things.

flourishing seems to require more than simple need satisfaction: it demands that needs be satisfied in particular ways, in ways that meet the subjective demands of individuals.

For instance, a sick child may have an objective need for a particular medicine if he is to get well. If the medicine has a foul taste he may not *want* to take the medication; but this does not mean that he *needs* the medicine any less. It can be difficult to convince the child that the medicine serves his best interests when it tastes like poison: even if you succeed in convincing him that he needs the medicine, you may not yet succeed in convincing him to actually *take* the medicine. This is why pharmaceutical companies give their medications an appealing flavor: sometimes our ultimate well-being depends upon the alignment of our needs with our wants.

Despite this overlap, I use the terms “need” and “want” in distinct ways in this paper, because I do think that doing so can help us differentiate between *aspects* of need. Thus, by “needs” I refer to those things objectively required for a flourishing human life.¹³ These things may be further grouped into two categories. “Vital needs” are the basic biological needs that must be met to ensure survival, such as food, water, protection from the elements, etc. “Social needs” are those which must be met to ensure flourishing, such as security, love, esteem (by self and others), and self-actualization.¹⁴

¹³ The definition of “flourishing” itself is, of course, a matter of great philosophical interest. Here it is simply taken to refer to a state of well-being in which one is fulfilled emotionally, psychologically, and socially. I base this discussion on Maslow’s hierarchy of needs, found in Abraham Maslow, “A Theory of Human Motivation,” *Psychological Review* 50.4 (1943): 370-396. Maslow’s hierarchy, of course, is not taken dogmatically, as it is certainly not without its own difficulties. See Ross Fitzgerald, “Abraham Maslow’s Hierarchy of Needs – An Exposition and Evaluation,” In *Human Needs and Politics*, ed. by Ross Fitzgerald (New York: Pergamon Press, 1977), 36-51.

¹⁴ Maslow, “A Theory of Human Motivation,” 370-396.

By “wants,” I mean those things that we subjectively and consciously seek to acquire and/or possess.¹⁵ As we have already seen, wants may overlap with needs, though it is possible for us to not want the things that we need, or for us to want things that we do not need. A flourishing human life is most efficiently achieved when an individual is able to identify their needs (both vital and social), has the necessary motivation to seek out the satisfaction of their needs (feelings of want aligning with needs), and has the resources (physical, mental, financial, etc.) required to acquire the objects that will satisfy their needs.

Marcuse’s Need Theory

Marcuse’s need theory begins in earnest when he declares that “the intensity, the satisfaction and even the character of human needs, beyond the biological level, have always been preconditioned.”¹⁶ In this first statement, Marcuse recognizes that human beings have two categories of needs: what I have called “vital needs,” and “social needs.” According to Marcuse, the social needs are “preconditioned,” constructed by the needs of particular societies in particular historical periods:

Whether or not the possibility of doing or leaving, enjoying or destroying, possessing or rejecting something is seized as a *need* depends upon whether or not it can be seen as desirable and necessary for the prevailing societal institutions and interests.¹⁷

¹⁵ These “things” may be either material (a sports car) or immaterial (praise).

¹⁶ Marcuse, *ODM*, 4.

¹⁷ *Ibid.*, 4.

Marcuse claims that advanced industrial society is characterized by domination in that many of us are driven to labor far beyond what is required to satisfy our needs.¹⁸ In his view, human beings would not devote themselves to such extreme degrees of unnecessary work if they knew that this surplus labor was beyond that required for the satisfaction of their needs. But what power could persuade people to unnecessarily sacrifice their time, their energy, their quality of life? It is at this point that Marcuse draws a distinction between true and false needs to explain how this system of domination perpetuates itself.¹⁹ He begins by describing false needs as:

those which are superimposed upon the individual by particular social interests in his repression: the needs which perpetuate toil, aggressiveness, misery, and injustice. Their satisfaction might be most gratifying to the individual, but this happiness is not a condition which has to be maintained and protected if it serves to arrest the development of the ability (his own and others) to recognize the disease of the whole and grasp the chances of curing the disease. The result then is euphoria in unhappiness. Most of the prevailing needs to relax, to have fun, to behave and consume in accordance with the advertisements, to love and hate what others love and hate, belong to this category of false needs.²⁰

Thus, Marcuse defines false needs as “the needs which perpetuate toil, aggressiveness, misery, and injustice.” They are, in essence, legitimate needs which yield harmful effects upon their satisfaction, as opposed to effects that lead to flourishing. It is important to note here that Marcuse acknowledges a subjective dimension of need, as well as the potential of wants and needs to overlap - even when the needs themselves are “false.” Members of our society may sincerely *feel* the false needs that he describes as their very own, and experience gratification when these needs are met - but this satisfaction ultimately does not help them flourish. Instead, it leads to the perpetuation of the societal conditions that require surplus labor, surplus repression.

¹⁸ See Herbert Marcuse, *Eros and Civilization: A Philosophical Inquiry into Freud* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1955), 34-38.

¹⁹ The characterization of these needs as “false” is inspired by the Marxist concept of “false consciousness,” in which capitalist ideology “infiltrates” the individual psyche. Interestingly, Marx himself never refers to “false consciousness.” The term was actually coined by Friedrich Engels in his personal correspondence. See Friedrich Engels, “Engels to Franz Mehring,” *Marx and Engels Correspondence*, trans. Donna Torr (New York: International Publishers, 1968), accessed May 20, 2016, https://www.marxists.org/archive/marx/works/1893/letters/93_07_14.htm.

²⁰ Marcuse, *ODM*, 4-5.

To be extra clear about how false needs work, it may be helpful to consider an example of need satisfaction. This may help us determine which stages in the process – if any at all – may be rightly deemed “false.”

For instance, let’s say that after a long day of alienating labor and toil, I feel physically and mentally worn out, and I perceive that I *need* to relax by interpreting various physiological signals (for instance, a headache, or muscle pain). My physical fatigue is so acute in this case that it inspires a *want* to relax; that is, when I become consciously aware of my fatigue as I interpret the relevant physiological signals, I recognize relaxation as a potential remedy to my fatigue, and seek it out by engaging in activities that habitually result in the relief of said fatigue. Which steps in this process could potentially be “false” and make this need a false need? Is it my perception of my objective need, my desire to have my need satisfied, or the activities in which I participate to satisfy my need? Let’s consider each of these possibilities in turn.

Perhaps my need to relax is false in this way: though I think my body is telling me that I am fatigued, in reality I do not actually need to relax. This is a strange thought, since we tend to think of fatigue as something known through certain physiological signals, and do not tend to think of it as a deceptive physical state. We usually declare that we *are* tired when we *feel* tired, and the feeling itself is generally what warrants this assessment. At any rate, it does not seem that this is the kind of phenomenon that Marcuse is talking about when he writes about false needs.

Perhaps my need to relax is false because, though I *want* to relax, in reality I do not need to relax, since I have been relaxing for nearly an entire month. I simply *want* relaxation, and I interpret my feelings of want as need because I want to continue relaxing so badly. Here, I

confuse my wants with my needs and am unable to distinguish between what I consciously desire and what will objectively lead to my benefit. But if need/want confusion is all there is to the phenomenon of false needs, Marcuse's distinction between true and false needs is redundant and extraneous. Thus it does not seem that Marcuse thinks that this kind of confusion constitutes false need.

Perhaps my need to relax is false because, though I feel fatigued and want to relax, I choose to engage in activities that ultimately do not satisfy my need to relax. For instance, though my fatigue suggests that I should take time to rest my body and mind, I instead dive into reading Hegel's *Phenomenology of Spirit*. In this example, I have an objective need as well as a subjective desire to satisfy this need; but I ultimately fail to satisfy my need because I have chosen an activity not conducive to relaxation. Once again, however, this is not what Marcuse means by false need, since in this example, need satisfaction does not occur. As we saw in the passage cited above, Marcuse believes that false needs can be satisfied, and that their satisfaction can actually be highly gratifying to the individual. So what are false needs according to Marcuse? I would like to suggest that Marcuse thinks of *false needs as actual needs*.²¹

Throughout his discussion of true and false needs, Marcuse does not equate the distinction between true and false needs with the distinction between needs and wants. Instead, he simply claims that false needs are "superimposed" on individuals, and states that they serve to "perpetuate toil, aggressiveness, misery, and injustice."²² This negative result is critical to

²¹ To clarify, I am arguing that Marcuse believes that both true and false needs are "actual," or "real" needs. By "actual," or "real," I mean that both true and false needs are objective human needs. False needs are not things I think I need, but that I actually only want; they are genuine needs, but they are needs imposed on me by the society in which I live, needs which do not lead to my flourishing upon their satisfaction.

²² Marcuse, *ODM*, 5.

Marcuse's definition of false needs. For Marcuse, the truth or falsity of needs is fully dependent upon whether their respective fulfillment leads to authenticity/expression or alienation/repression. He recognizes false needs as actual needs: they are not wants or desires masquerading as needs, but rather, they are needs which, once fulfilled, lead to the ultimate repression of individuals. The problem with advanced industrial society is not that it makes people want the wrong things, but rather, that it creates needs in individuals that ultimately yield harm upon satisfaction. But how does this happen?

To return to our relaxation example, Marcuse would say that the organization of advanced industrial society puts me in a position where I am so stressed, exhausted, and unfulfilled from my labor that I feel a need to relax in order to recover just enough to continue working in such inhumane conditions. This need to relax is real. I feel the need to relax, and I actually need to relax if I am going to continue my daily labor, since the arrangement of advanced industrial society demands that I continue to labor if I am to satisfy even my most basic needs. But when I relax, I do nothing to change the system that dominates me, the socioeconomic arrangement that makes me need relaxation in the first place. I simply "recharge my batteries" and prepare myself for another grueling day of alienated labor, after which I will need to recharge my batteries yet again. This is what Marcuse refers to when he writes:

The distinguishing feature of advanced industrial society is its effective suffocation of those needs which demand liberation – liberation also from that which is tolerable and rewarding and comfortable – while it sustains and absolves the destructive power and repressive function of the affluent society. Here, the social controls exact the overwhelming need for the production and consumption of waste; the need for stupefying work where it is no longer a real necessity; the need for modes of relaxation which soothe and prolong this stupefaction...²³

²³ Ibid., 7.

Advanced industrial society superimposes real, objective needs upon individuals for things that ultimately serve societal interests, at the cost of individual detriment. This is what makes false needs “false.” Marcuse’s concept of false needs is innovative because it tells us that our society has warped and convoluted our needs. It introduces “layers” of artificial, yet-real needs that must first be met before we can satisfy our needs related to individual flourishing. In advanced industrial society, false needs “stack up” upon our true needs, and obscure alternative courses of fulfillment.

For example, I have a need for esteem from others that I could potentially satisfy by engaging in any number of esteem-earning activities. For instance, I could earn the esteem of others by involving myself in charity work, or by generally treating others with dignity and respect. But according to Marcuse, the demands of our society have obscured this kind of path to esteem, and have instead promoted paths to esteem that ultimately lead to toil and misery; for instance, advertisements suggest that I could win the esteem of others by driving a flashy, expensive sports car, like an Aston-Martin. The ads suggest that if I own a car that others recognize as a status symbol, I will gain their esteem. Thus, my need for esteem may become joined with my need to own such a car. Status symbols, however, do not come cheaply. I will need to work many hours to have the buying power required to purchase such an important status symbol. Now my need for esteem is joined with my need to own a flashy car, which is joined with my need to work many hours. If my job is alienating and dehumanizing, my efforts to satisfy my need for esteem will now result in toil and misery.

Recall that we have defined needs earlier in this paper as universal life necessities, things that are absolutely required for flourishing human life. Esteem qualifies as such a need. But what about the need for a sports car, or the need to work many hours? Are these absolutely,

universally required for flourishing human life? No, certainly not. Only a car salesman might suggest that a flashy car is a universal necessity. I feel confident in asserting that many human beings live, and have lived, flourishing lives without owning an Aston-Martin. But also recall that Marcuse is not concerned so much with *universal* needs; remember, he states that all of our social (non-vital) needs are socially and historically conditioned. Thus, according to Marcuse, we must consider the legitimacy of needs as they appear in particular social and historical contexts. In his view, the need for esteem is not a need for some abstract, ideal, universal concept: it is a need grounded in culture. So, while it would be laughable to suggest that the need for an Aston-Martin is a universal human need, in advanced industrial society, we are led to believe that acquiring such a luxuriant automobile may be a near-guarantor of esteem. If you want to satisfy your need for esteem in advanced industrial society, you have to play by its rules, and the vast majority do. When the majority of people in society agree that the possession of certain symbolic items merit esteem, it becomes increasingly necessary to acquire those symbolic items to earn their esteem.²⁴

One of the most insidious effects of false needs is that they are able to “penetrate” subjectivity and appear part of it:

No matter how much such needs may have become the individual’s own, reproduced and fortified by the conditions of his existence; no matter how much he identifies himself with them and finds himself in their satisfaction, they continue to be what they were from the beginning – products of a society whose dominant interest demands repression.²⁵

This passage also suggests that false needs are real needs. The societal situation of domination imposes needs upon people to such a degree that they can “become the individual’s

²⁴ Ibid., xlv: “The fact that the vast majority of the population accepts, and is made to accept, this society does not render it less irrational and less reprehensible.”

²⁵ Ibid., 5.

own.” When society tells me that I need a flashy car to earn the esteem of others, I correspondingly recognize flashy cars as symbolic objects that entitle the possessor to my esteem. The need for a flashy car becomes my own need, and it also becomes a criterion by which I might determine which people deserve my esteem. When a majority of people in a society hold such opinions about particular needs, the alleged “universality” of needs is irrelevant.²⁶ Thus, needs which were “artificial” (sports car) in relation to the “original” need (esteem) become just as real, in a *social* sense.

Let us now turn to what little Marcuse has to say about our true needs:

The only needs that have an unqualified claim for satisfaction are the vital ones – nourishment, clothing, lodging at the attainable level of culture. The satisfaction of these needs is the prerequisite for the realization of *all* needs...²⁷

Marcuse states that our vital needs alone have an indisputable claim for satisfaction, which suggests that they are true needs. This is, of course, a somewhat obvious point; so what else might qualify as a true need? In this portion of the text, Marcuse is hesitant to designate other true needs in specific detail, since in his view, non-vital needs are necessarily preconditioned, historically constructed. He only goes so far as to suggest that true needs will only become apparent once our vital needs are universally satisfied, when toil and poverty are

²⁶ Ibid., 8: “If the worker and his boss enjoy the same television program and visit the same resort places, if the typist is as attractively made up as the daughter of her employer, if the Negro owns a Cadillac, if they all read the same newspaper, then this assimilation indicates not the disappearance of classes, but the extent to which the needs and satisfactions that serve the preservation of the Establishment are shared by the underlying population.”

²⁷ Ibid., 5.

alleviated.²⁸ Only in such conditions will human beings be properly situated to judge and prioritize needs.²⁹

Marcuse believes, however, that it will be quite difficult to arrive at such a situation, since false needs are part of a vicious circle of domination.³⁰ False needs perpetuate toil and misery; but false needs cannot be eliminated until toil and misery have ceased. This is a problem for any commentator who would seek to generate a list of true needs within a Marcusean framework. We cannot know with absolute certainty how our true human needs will appear until we live in the society which allows us to recognize them. Nevertheless, Marcuse's conception of false needs can give us some general direction concerning his conception of true needs.³¹ For instance, if false needs are those which perpetuate injustice through their satisfaction, it seems relatively safe to say that the satisfaction of a true need would perpetuate justice. Likewise, if the satisfaction of false needs perpetuates toil, alienated labor, then the satisfaction of true needs should perpetuate something other, like free creativity, recreation, or non-alienated labor.

One final illustration will help describe my view of Marcuse's need theory. Let's start simply: I need something to eat. Since I need food to survive, this is a vital need, and as such, it is an indisputable true need. Now, let us suppose that in my city, the *only* way I can satisfy my

²⁸ Ibid., 6: The insinuation that many people do not know what their true needs are (while certain intellectuals do) is one claim that opens Marcuse up to accusations of elitism.

²⁹ Ibid., 6.

³⁰ Herbert Marcuse, *Five Lectures: Psychoanalysis, Politics, and Utopia*, trans. By Jeremy J. Shapiro and Shierry M. Weber (Boston: Beacon Press, 1970), 80: In a Q&A session following Marcuse's lecture on "The End of Utopia," an audience member comments: "It seemed to me that the center of your paper today was the thesis that a transformation of society must be preceded by a transformation of needs. For me this implies that changed needs can arise only if we first abolish the mechanisms that have let the needs come into being as they are. It seems to me that you have shifted the accent toward enlightenment and away from revolution." Marcuse responds: "You have defined what is unfortunately the greatest difficulty in the matter. Your objection is that, for new, revolutionary needs to develop, the mechanisms that reproduce the old needs must be abolished. In order for the mechanisms to be abolished, there must first be a need to abolish them. That is the circle in which we are placed, and I do not know how to get out of it."

³¹ This direction may only be of trivial worth since it points to rather generic, abstract values.

need for food is to eat a Big Mac, since my local government has declared that McDonald's restaurants will be the only food preparation facilities allowed within the city limits. Do I need the Big Mac? In this scenario, yes, I do. Technically, I just need nourishment in general, which on some level the Big Mac (arguably) provides; but if it is my only (or best) option to satisfy my universal need for nutrition, I accordingly also have a need for the Big Mac. This need is socially and historically superimposed upon me, since local political decisions have designated McDonald's as the sole corporation that attends to nourishment needs; but it is nevertheless a very real need. However, even though I have a real need for Big Macs, eating a Big Mac three times a day every day is not good for my long-term health. In fact, it is likely that living on such a diet will cause substantial harm to my health before long. Thus, my need for a Big Mac is a false need. It is a real need, one superimposed upon me by the society in which I live, the satisfaction of which ultimately results in my harm, as opposed to my flourishing.

A likely objection to this illustration is the fact that, in our society, our options for need satisfaction are not as narrowly limited as they are in my contrived scenario. Many of us can choose not to eat a Big Mac, and can opt instead for a salad - something more nutritious, less detrimental. In fact, as this rebuttal may proceed, our society is generally ripe with choice. We can choose to work towards the purchase of an Aston-Martin in hopes of one day receiving the esteem of others, or we can engage in humanitarian efforts in hopes of one day achieving said esteem. Our society allows for the proliferation of many means of need satisfaction.

But notice that at a most basic level, members of our society must generally have financial resources at their disposal if they are to satisfy their basic needs. Yes, technically we are free to pursue the esteem of others either by purchasing an Aston-Martin or by serving the community as a humanitarian. One is free to reject the materialistic values of our society if one

desires. But if your humanitarian efforts are not also a source of income, you may not be able to meet your basic needs. So, while we do have some modicum of choice, it is nevertheless within a society ultimately founded upon coercion: one must work if one is to satisfy one's basic needs. While there are positive aspects of the degree of choice that we may enjoy in our society, I side with Marcuse's observation that "under the rule of an oppressive whole, liberty can be made into a powerful instrument of domination."³² Like Marx before him, Marcuse is ultimately concerned with the prevalence of alienated labor, a situation in which people are systematically persuaded to sacrifice their own flourishing for the sake of less-fulfilling objectives.

William Leiss's Critique of False Needs

Now that I have described Marcuse's need theory, I will respond to his leading critic, William Leiss, and demonstrate that he does not properly understand Marcuse's concept of false needs. Whereas Marcuse describes false needs in order to explain how advanced industrial society is able to coerce individuals into perpetuating ends other than their own, Leiss holds individuals responsible for their unmet needs.

In *The Limits to Satisfaction*, Leiss takes issue with Marcuse's claim that advanced industrial society systemically produces *false* needs in individuals. His argument is succinct:

The critical viewpoint has based its negative judgment of the high-consumption lifestyle on some form of the distinction between spontaneous vs. artificial or true vs. false needs. The sheer volume of advertising in modern capitalist societies appears to lend this thesis a plausible air. Why else

³² Marcuse, *ODM*, 7: "The range of choice open to the individual is not the decisive factor in determining the degree of human freedom, but *what* can be chosen and what *is* chosen by the individual. The criterion for free choice can never be an absolute one, but neither is it entirely relative. Free election of masters does not abolish the masters or the slaves. Free choice among a wide variety of goods and services does not signify freedom if these goods and services sustain social controls over a life of toil and fear – that is, if they sustain alienation. And the spontaneous reproduction of superimposed needs by the individual does not establish autonomy; it only testifies to the efficacy of the controls."

would such an intensive effort at persuasion be necessary? Yet if the socialization process is so intense that the imperatives of the capitalist market economy itself (the necessity in the productive system for continually expanding the realm of commodities) become internalized as deeply felt needs in the experience of individuals, as Marcuse has argued, are there reasonable grounds for describing them as false needs?...The state of confusion is rooted in the interplay between needs and commodities. This is not a matter of false needs. In my view the jungle of commodities have for the most part a reasonable and sensible set of needs; however, they do misinterpret the relationship between their perceived needs and the possible sources of satisfaction for them.³³

According to Leiss, the claim that social needs are socially and historically produced means that all needs have an equal claim to legitimacy. The social problems that we experience in a capitalist market economy are not due to the production of false needs, but rather, from individuals' confusion about the best way to satisfy their needs. Leiss emphasizes the freedom of a capitalist market economy as opposed to the coercive aspects that Marcuse describes. For Leiss, individuals have a multitude of options set before them to satisfy their needs. Individuals simply need to do a better job of discerning what their needs are, in the first place, and a better job at seeking out the commodities they hope will satisfy their needs, in the second.

But Leiss fails to grasp what I see as the paradoxical nature of Marcuse's conception of false needs. As we have seen, Marcuse's innovation is that he conceives of a species of needs that violates the very definition of needs: false needs are not simply a matter of wanting the wrong things, but rather, they are actual needs which lead to harm instead of flourishing upon satisfaction. This fundamental facet of Marcuse's need theory is entirely absent from Leiss's critique. In Leiss's view, what Marcuse would call a "false need" is simply a situation in which an individual has failed to understand that the object they think they need is but a *means* to what they really need. An individual thinks they need an Aston-Martin, but they really need the esteem of others. Leiss apparently thinks that this is something that may be easily rectified: the

³³ Leiss, *Limits to Satisfaction*, 59. This argument is also made in Leiss, "Needs, Exchanges, and the Fetishism of Objects, 27-48; and in Kline and Leiss, "Advertising, Needs, and 'Commodity Fetishism,'" 5-30.

individual just needs to be made aware of the relationship between the sports car and the esteem that they seek.

I gather that Leiss imagines false needs emerging in circumstances far more free than those Marcuse describes. With Marcuse, we saw that needs “stack up” in layers (I need to relax because I need to work overtime because I need money because I need to buy a fancy car because I need the esteem of others) and become woven together in a way in which beneficial ends are achieved through detrimental means, largely because of social pressure. If everyone in my society symbolically links particular objects to esteem, and I have a need for esteem, my society plays a critical part in my motivations to acquire those symbolic objects.

Here is where Marcuse and Leiss part ways: Marcuse recognizes how difficult (or even impossible) it may be for an individual to “excise” the false needs that are bound up with true needs, while Leiss thinks it is easier for individuals to transcend the system of fetish objects within a particular society.³⁴ Leiss notes that the link between a nice car and the esteem of others is artificial and tenuous, and thus he thinks that a rejection of this link is all one needs to be able to discover her or his true need for the esteem of others. For Marcuse, on the other hand, it is difficult for an individual to ignore social links between fetish objects and true objects of need. If the majority of people in my society think that esteem is only due to those who own a nice car, I may have a hard time earning their esteem via other methods. Though I would ideally live in a society in which esteem is earned without needing to buy certain fetish objects, if I am a member

³⁴ Leiss actually provides an important key to understanding the power of false needs with what he hopes will undermine the concept, largely because he underestimates the potency of commodity fetishization. Leiss appears to underestimate the power and influence of social construction, a process one cannot easily transcend.

of advanced industrial society, I am bound to participate in the pre-established avenues of need fulfillment.

Conclusions

I have argued that understanding Marcuse's false needs as a paradoxical concept can help us avoid some of the problems that arise when we think of false needs as misguided wants, or erroneous desires. In my interpretation, false needs are real needs that are superimposed upon us by advanced industrial society, needs that violate the very definition of need itself by perpetuating misery and harm as opposed to flourishing and health. Because false needs "bind" themselves to our true needs, the satisfaction of the latter often requires the satisfaction of the former; for every step forward, we take two steps backward.

This is not to say, however, that the *products* of advanced industrial society are necessarily corrupt. There is nothing wrong with owning an Aston-Martin in itself, nothing wrong with human beings discovering various ways to experience pleasurable aspects of the world through innovation. In fact, the drive to experience the world through our own innovation is a critical part of Marx's early philosophy. Thus the real question is: can we bring about a world in which enjoyment and innovation are not solely the fruits of alienated labor?

A common objection to Marxist reorganizations of society is that economic competition in free markets is what drives innovation, what inspires human beings to invent new and better products. This view is quite cynical however, as it implies that without *economic* competition, human beings would have no interest in creativity, no interest in producing technologies to improve our lives. But Marx - and likely Marcuse - would suggest that human beings have a

deep *need* to experience our environment in creative, self-fulfilling ways. It is an ontological fact about humanity that we seek expression in our labors.

From this perspective, the advanced industrial economy reveals itself as the ultimate false need. It binds itself to things which give us pleasure in life, and demands that those things come at the harmful cost of alienated labor. Indeed, in our time, alternative forces of production appear idealistic and unrealistic. But I surmise that the prevalence of nonalienated labor would give rise to an equally productive regime, one in which our collective creative potential is unadulterated by toil, aggressiveness, misery, and injustice.

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